Flex Application Tips and Tricks with AIR

As described earlier in this chapter, the subject of developing Flex applications for desktop deployment with AIR is too large for a single chapter. There are, however, a few specific things you do a bit differently in a desktop application, and there are many Flex SDK features that are available only when you're developing for AIR including Debugging AIR applications in Flash Builder, Rendering and managing HTML-based and PDF-based content, Using the WindowedApplication component as the application's root element and Creating channels at runtime for communicating with Remoting gateways

Debugging AIR applications in Flash Builder

For the most part, debugging an AIR application in Flash Builder is just like debugging a Webbased Flex application. You have access to all the same debugging tools, including the trace() function, breakpoints, and the capability to inspect the values of application variables when the application is suspended.

When you run a Flex application from within Flash Builder in either standard or debug mode, Flash Builder uses ADL (AIR Debug Launcher) in the background. In some cases, ADL can stay in system memory with hidden windows even after an AIR application session has apparently been closed. The symptom for this condition is that when you try to run or debug that or another application, Flash Builder simply does nothing. Because a debugging session is still in memory, Flash Builder can't start a new one.

Open the Windows Task Manager and in the Processes pane, locate and select the entry for adl.exe. Click End Process to force ADL to shut down and then close Task Manager, and return to Flash Builder. You should now be able to start your next AIR application session successfully. One common scenario that can result in this problem is when a runtime error occurs during execution of startup code. For example, if you make a call to a server-based resource from an application-level creation Complete event handler and an unhandled fault occurs, the application window might never become visible. If you're running the application in debug mode, you can commonly clear the ADL from memory by terminating the debugging session from within Flash Builder. When running in standard mode, however, the ADL can be left in memory with the window not yet visible. To solve this issue, it's a good idea to explicitly set the application's initial windows as visible. In the application descriptor file, the <initialWindow>